

Chapter 118-1

It was already past eleven o'clock, and the rhythm of the entire city had slowed down, with traffic on the roads decreasing.

The cold wind of late autumn had already stripped the leaves from the branches of trees on both sides of the road, leaving them all bare.

In a coffee shop diagonally across from Ruijing Hotel, there were very few customers, with only the innermost table occupied.

Black long hair, wearing a blue hat, a puff-sleeve fitted top, high-waisted wide-leg pants that made her waist look slender.

She had ordered a cappuccino and was sitting in the corner.

But the heat from the coffee had already dissipated, and the latte art on the surface remained untouched. She kept her head down, constantly poking at her phone.

The contact name on the screen was an emoji: sheep.

[Still not coming?]

[If you don't come, I'm leaving.]

[The coffee shop is about to close.]

The other person only replied with one sentence: [Almost there.]

The person playing with her phone replied impatiently: [So slow.]

Just as this message was sent, the coffee shop door was pushed open.

A woman in a grass-green coat brushed back her wind-tousled curly hair. When the staff came forward and said to her: "Miss, we're about to close," the woman raised her chin: "I'm looking for someone."

As for whom she was looking for, it went without saying.

There was only this one customer in the entire shop. The staff member also felt exhausted. Originally, they were supposed to close at eleven, but this young lady had come in at ten-thirty, ordered a cup of coffee, and just sat there. It was already past their closing time. They had already given a subtle reminder once, but she had only said: "Wait a bit longer."

She hadn't even drunk the coffee.

The shop couldn't forcibly drive out customers at closing time. Several staff members who had been standing all day and were exhausted to death kept staring at that customer, just hoping she would be considerate.

But they didn't expect that customer was waiting for a friend.

If they chatted in the shop for a while longer..

Just thinking about it made the staff member's scalp tingle.

Zhang Yangning, who had barely managed to extract herself from a drinking party after organizing a welcome ceremony for a newly hired employee, arrived late, still reeking of alcohol.

Zhang Yangning walked to the table in the corner and sat down. After taking a sip of the coffee that had already cooled on the table, she immediately frowned: "What is this taste?"

"It's been sitting for an hour," the person across from her said, her voice cold, carrying several notes of gloom.

Zhang Yangning placed her bag on the chair beside her and raised her hand to ask the staff for a glass of water.

The staff member hesitated, but then Zhang Yangning's phoenix eyes slanted upward: "No coffee, and not even a glass of water?"

"We have it." To avoid trouble, the staff member immediately went to pour her a glass of water.

Zhang Yangning took a sip—it was a bit hot. She frowned, about to lose her temper, but was stopped by the person across from her: "That's enough."

"Ranran." After drinking the water, her throat wasn't as parched as before, and her speech became softer. She smiled at the person across from her: "You're angry."

Only then did the woman raise her head. Her eyes were impossibly red, looking rather frightening.

It was Liang Xinran.

Zhang Yangning was also startled: "My god, sweetie, what happened to you? Why are your eyes like a little rabbit's?"

"Cried too much," Liang Xinran said coldly.

Zhang Yangning: "....."

"What happened?" Zhang Yangning asked.

Liang Xinran glanced at the water in her hand: "Done drinking? Let's talk outside."

Zhang Yangning hesitated, not really wanting to go outside and be blown by the cold wind. But Liang Xinran had already gotten up and was heading out.

A few seconds later, Zhang Yangning gulped down the water, grabbed her bag from the chair, and followed.

Her bag was a name brand, five figures¹.

The clothes on her body were also quite pricey.

After they left, the coffee shop staff were still gossiping—that person's demeanor was like a nouveau riche.

Zhang Yangning, who had already left, didn't know this. As soon as she went out, she was frozen through. She chased after Liang Xinran asking: "Where are we going?"

Liang Xinran said: "Don't talk for now."

Zhang Yangning: "....."

She looked around—nothing unusual.

Besides, out here on the main street, so far from the Liang family and Dongheng, who could see the two of them?

Really paranoid.

However, Zhang Yangning only thought this in her heart and obediently did as Liang Xinran said.

Footnote:

¹ Five figures (五位数): Refers to the price being in the tens of thousands (10,000-99,999 RMB, approximately \$1,400-\$14,000 USD), indicating an expensive designer bag.

Chapter 118-2

There was a small alley connecting two main roads. Few people passed through the alley, and one of the streetlights was broken and hadn't been fixed yet.

Liang Xinran stood in the middle of the alley waiting for the other person.

A moment later, Zhang Yangning came running over, panting: "I'm not saying this to criticize, but your legs aren't that long, so how come you walk like you've got a motor installed?"

"You're too slow," Liang Xinran said without changing expression.

Zhang Yangning instinctively replied: "You like it better when I'm slower in bed."

After these words came out, the atmosphere extended into some awkwardness.

Liang Xinran glanced at her sidelong: "You only remember those bedroom matters. Annoying, isn't it?"

"Why don't we try tonight and find out?" As Zhang Yangning spoke, she pressed Liang Xinran against the wall, her hand burrowing under her clothes: "You want it too, don't you?"

Liang Xinran was caught off guard, her slender back slamming hard against the cold wall. The pain made her curse.

"Fucking be gentler," Liang Xinran said unhappily.

Zhang Yangning sneered: "We're already here—what's the point of being gentle?"

Zhang Yangning leaned closer to her, her movements lascivious: "It needs to be rough to feel anything. Aren't you into it?"

Liang Xinran: ".....I'm into jack shit."

Liang Xinran pushed her away and said seriously: "Let's talk business."

Zhang Yangning, whose hands came up empty after being pushed away, still wasn't willing to give up and squeezed her chest, saying in a frivolous manner: "Life at the Liang family is treating you well—these have gotten bigger."

She never spoke seriously in front of Liang Xinran, always acting like a hoodlum.

Liang Xinran glanced at her and extended her hand: "Give me a cigarette."

Zhang Yangning slowly fished out cigarettes and a lighter from her bag, handing them over while asking: "How did you get out of the Liang house? And you dare to contact me? Aren't you afraid of being traced?"

"If we're traced, I'll just say we're from the same hometown." Liang Xinran exhaled a puff of smoke, waving her hand in front of her to disperse it. "It's not like I did anything."

Zhang Yangning laughed: "Nothing?"

"That kid's incident wasn't my doing," Liang Xinran said. "She was careless herself."

Zhang Yangning couldn't be bothered to argue with her and smiled perfunctorily: "Sure, sure, sure."

"When you talked to Xu Kang, you weren't recorded or anything, were you?" Liang Xinran asked.

Zhang Yangning shook her head: "No. Besides, I didn't do anything. I just gave him a little hint. The idea was all his wife's. And it's not like this is the first or second time those two have pulled this kind of thing. It's not a big deal."

Liang Xinran nodded slightly and didn't say anything more for the moment.

Zhang Yangning also lit up a cigarette and asked her: "You're not going back tonight?"

Liang Xinran said: "I was kicked out."

Zhang Yangning: "....."

"Seriously, that's it?" Zhang Yangning said irritably. "I told you not to rush. What kind of family is the Liang family? You think those people are pushovers? They're not your stupid dad who doesn't understand anything, and they're not your mom who only knows how to have kids. Your little tricks..."

"Enough!" Liang Xinran frowned and shouted in a low voice: "I didn't call you here to listen to you lecture me."

Zhang Yangning paused for a few seconds: "Then what do you want to do?"

"My mom will come looking for me again," Liang Xinran said. "Does Liang Xinzhou think that kicking me out means it's over? Too naive."

Zhang Yangning looked at her and couldn't help saying: "I don't understand—why do you have to drive a wedge between them? Can't you just be a proper Third Miss of the Liang family? Give you a little bit and your second half of life would be comfortable enough."

"Why should I only get a little bit?" Liang Xinran said. "Didn't they say I'm their most beloved child? They lost me for so many years, but I haven't seen them give me any compensation."

Liang Xinran's eyes were gloomy as she stared at a black insect on the ground by her feet. She slightly raised her foot and brought it down hard, stepping on that insect.

Crushed it directly.

Her voice was several degrees colder than this late autumn evening wind: "They've been young masters and wealthy misses for so many years—that's enough. Leave the rest to me."

Zhang Yangning: "....."

This alley was cold and deserted, the cold wind howling through.

Zhang Yangning looked at her and suddenly smiled—still the same Liang Xinran.

"So many years have passed," Zhang Yangning laughed cheerfully. "You fucking haven't changed at all."

Liang Xinran sneered lightly: "Same goes for you."

Zhang Yangning suddenly remembered seven-year-old Liang Xinran—back then she was still called Guo Xinran.

Because her mother was pregnant with a second child, her father, emboldened by having a new kid, treated her especially badly, beating and scolding her at every turn.

Zhang Yangning had encountered this girl by the stream outside the village.

At that time, Zhang Yangning wasn't that old either. She was holding a snake and drowning it in the water, with a secretive pleasure on her face.

Seeing Guo Xinran staring at her, she shouted: "What? You want to be drowned too?"

Guo Xinran jumped directly into the water, walking toward her step by step, her gaze burning, and the first thing she said was: "Kill me."

It completely stunned Zhang Yangning.

But Guo Xinran's second sentence was: "Or kill the child in my mom's belly, and I'll be at your command."

Chapter 118-3

.....

Memories came flooding back, that figure overlapping with the present.

Liang Xinran was still that person who dared to do anything when pushed to the edge.

After the silence, Zhang Yangning asked her: "So how are you going back?"

"I left a letter there," Liang Xinran said. "My mom will come looking for me. Before that, find me a place to stay."

Zhang Yangning took a drag from her cigarette: "Come to my place?"

"One night is fine," Liang Xinran leaned against the wall. "Do you have condoms at your place?"

"We can just buy some," Zhang Yangning laughed. "Besides, baby, you didn't think I'd stay faithful to you, did you?"

Liang Xinran's expression stiffened for a moment, then she sneered lightly: "Dirty."

"How are you any cleaner?" Zhang Yangning reached out and slapped her on the butt. "Remember when you rolled into the CEO of Zuoye Culture's bed?"

Liang Xinran paused before saying: "Her technique isn't as good as yours."

Zhang Yangning moved closer to her: "Of course—after all, I was your first woman."

After a while, she asked again: "Do you still have money?"

"How much do you need?" Liang Xinran asked.

"Five hundred thousand."

Liang Xinran frowned: "What do you need that much money for?"

"Entertaining clients," Zhang Yangning said. "I'm about to get promoted. Treating people to meals and drinks—all of that needs money."

As Zhang Yangning spoke, her hands were already becoming restless. But Liang Xinran pressed down on her hand: "You're not using my money to support your women on the side, are you?"

Zhang Yangning laughed lightly, with a somewhat wicked edge: "How could that be? Baby, I only like you."

Liang Xinran was made somewhat comfortable by her touch, but still didn't relent: "Just a hundred thousand."

"You're the Third Miss of the Liang family now," Zhang Yangning said. "Why be stingy? Before long, the entire Liang family will be yours."

"Not yet."

"In due time."

Zhang Yangning ignored Liang Xinran's trembling voice and smiled coaxingly: "I'll help you."

Liang Xinran crushed the cigarette butt on the ground with her foot.

Her voice somewhat soft, she said: "We'll do it when we get home."

"So the five hundred thousand?" Zhang Yangning asked.

Liang Xinran: "Make me feel good first, then we'll talk."

Chapter 118-4

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The next morning, when Liang Shi woke up, her embrace was already empty.

She touched the sheets—there was still some residual warmth.

Xu Qingzhu couldn't have gotten up long ago.

Liang Shi raised her arm to cover her eyes and lazed in bed for a while longer.

She turned on her side, burying her head in the pillow. Her breath was filled entirely with the fragrance of Xu Qingzhu's hair.

Liang Shi felt content, the corners of her mouth unconsciously turning up.

A dreamless night, her body extraordinarily relaxed.

After getting up, Liang Shi folded the blanket and walked out. Rainbow was already sitting at the dining table eating.

Liang Shi slapped her forehead and suddenly asked: "Rainbow, what time do you go to kindergarten?"

Rainbow replied obediently: "Jiejie, there's still plenty of time."

Liang Shi breathed a sigh of relief: "I thought you were going to be late. Go ahead and eat, I'll take you to school after you're done."

Rainbow responded with an "oh."

Meanwhile, Xu Qingzhu ate quietly.

This morning was no different from usual. After washing up, Liang Shi sat down at the dining table. Seeing it was purple rice porridge and buns bought from downstairs, she asked Xu Qingzhu: "What time did you get up?"

"Ten minutes before you," Xu Qingzhu said.

"And you already went downstairs to buy food that quickly?" Liang Shi was surprised.

Xu Qingzhu paused, her tone complicated: "Rainbow bought it."

Liang Shi: "....."

"Baby, how did you go downstairs to buy things by yourself?" Liang Shi was shocked, even her tone of speech different from usual. "Weren't you afraid of bad people?"

"It's just downstairs in the residential complex," Rainbow said. "I usually go down to buy things by myself too."

Liang Shi: "....."

She and Xu Qingzhu exchanged glances, both seeing disbelief in each other's eyes.

"It's still better not to," Liang Shi instructed her. "There are lots of cars outside now, and you're still a child. Just peacefully enjoy what the adults do for you."

Rainbow was silent for a moment, then said in a little-adult tone: "These are all small matters~"

Liang Shi didn't know what else to say.

As she ate the fruits of Rainbow's labor, she felt a bit guilty inside.

As an adult, she had actually lazed in bed until a five-year-old child had to run errands to buy breakfast—she really had no self-awareness.

Though last night had indeed been... somewhat tiring.

They hadn't done anything excessive, just she and Xu Qingzhu chatting—talking about Qi Jiao, about Chen Mian, about Yang Shuyan. They talked about so many people, and somehow somewhere they'd be touched and would get tangled up kissing.

.....

It had indeed been somewhat debauched.

When Liang Shi was washing up earlier, she had discovered that the corner of her mouth was broken.

She hadn't been willing to use force on Xu Qingzhu, so Xu Qingzhu had used force on her.

She ate breakfast with her mind wandering. Her thoughts had initially been on Rainbow buying breakfast, but before long they shifted to another matter, the scale so large that Liang Shi pinched her ears.

After breakfast, Liang Shi took Rainbow to kindergarten early.

Similar to when picking her up, the entrance was packed with people. Rainbow could walk a distance by herself, but Liang Shi still parked the car a bit further out and held her hand to the kindergarten entrance.

After she entered the school, Liang Shi lingered for a while before leaving.

As she was leaving, she saw Yang Jiani bringing Gu Xingyue to school. She hid in the crowd and watched for a few moments.

Yang Jiani was still wearing a qipao¹, moon-blue colored, with a jade bracelet on her arm, making her appear graceful and distinguished.

And Gu Xingyue was dressed similarly to yesterday. For her, after so many years, each day of her life was pretty much the same—this day was no different.

It seemed like time was moving forward, but in Gu Xingyue's world...

Yesterday, today, tomorrow were all the same.

Because Gu Xingyue was in darkness, and the one who had appeared now was Qi Jiao.

Liang Shi watched as Yang Jiani kept her eyes on Gu Xingyue until she entered the school, looked around, then left.

After that car drove away, Liang Shi was about to head to her own car when she spotted Cheng Ru smoking not far away.

Footnote:

¹ Qipao (旗袍): Also known as cheongsam, a traditional Chinese dress with a high collar and side slits, often made of silk or brocade. It's considered elegant and is associated with sophistication and cultural refinement.

Chapter 118-5

Cheng Ru was wearing a light-colored casual suit, her glamorous big wavy curls casually tied back. Surprisingly, she wasn't wearing makeup, and her complexion was somewhat pale.

But from a distance, Liang Shi couldn't see too clearly.

She had no intention of going over to greet her, but after walking a few steps, she was called out to by Cheng Ru.

Cheng Ru extinguished the cigarette in her hand and casually tossed the butt into the trash can.

"What are you doing here?" Cheng Ru walked over to face Liang Shi.

Only then did Liang Shi see clearly—there were heavy dark circles under her eyes, making her look like she hadn't slept for several nights. Her clothes were also wrinkled, and there was even a lipstick mark on her crumpled collar.

Not knowing which woman had left it there.

A flash of disgust crossed Liang Shi's eyes.

"None of your business," Liang Shi replied coldly.

Cheng Ru's tongue pressed against her teeth. After a moment, she asked: "What's your relationship with Qi Jiao?"

"None of your concern," Liang Shi said.

Just as she finished speaking and was about to leave, Cheng Ru suddenly grabbed her by the collar like a madwoman and lifted her up, asking hysterically: "Did she fucking get together with you?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi was taller than her, so being treated so roughly didn't really choke her, but it severely injured her dignity.

Seeing the two of them making a scene at the kindergarten entrance, quite a few parents who had just dropped off their children cast their eyes over. Then the kindergarten security guard shouted: "What are you two doing? Break it up, break it up. Don't fight at the kindergarten entrance and set a bad example for the kids. Be careful or I'll call the police."

"Let go," Liang Shi said coldly, those light brown pupils staring icily at Cheng Ru. "Look at what you've become."

"Isn't it all because she pushed me to this?" Cheng Ru said through gritted teeth. "She's completely disappeared from my life."

Liang Shi returned her earlier words to her: "That's also because you pushed her to it."

Cheng Ru sneered: "What standing do you have to say that?"

Liang Shi removed her hand: "And what standing do you have to ask that?"

The two locked eyes, neither willing to yield.

A moment later, Cheng Ru laughed mockingly: "She got together with you, didn't she? Found her next option, so now she can be so unscrupulous."

"Liang Shi," Cheng Ru stared at her. "Didn't you fucking love Xu Qingzhu to death, willing to change for her? Why are you still doing this kind of shitty thing now? Isn't that cheap?"

Cheng Ru, who had lost her rationality in anger, cursed without holding back at all.

Liang Shi just looked at her calmly. At first, she had felt some angry emotions, but now she felt nothing—she just found this person pathetic.

"Whatever the relationship between her and me is has nothing to do with you," Liang Shi said. "I've already passed along what you said. Her response was..."

Liang Shi paused, then returned Gu Xingyue's answer to her word for word: "Who cares."

Even the tone was imitated to perfection.

Cheng Ru scoffed: "Of course she doesn't care now—she has you."

"Stop being crazy," Liang Shi glanced at her with disgust. "Cheng Ru, what do you mean by this now? Regretting it and coming to chase after her?"

Cheng Ru suddenly froze: "....."

A moment later, she instinctively said: "Why would I chase after her? She's just a woman."

Liang Shi: "....."

There was nothing to say to this kind of person.

Liang Shi was about to leave, but Cheng Ru grabbed her forearm: "Liang Shi, did you and her actually..."

"No," Liang Shi said coldly. "She and I are just friends in a pure relationship, not as filthy as you imagine. Also."

Liang Shi turned to look at her, frowning: "Cheng Ru, not everyone is as disgusting as you."

"I'm disgusting?" Cheng Ru was surprised, then laughed: "Liang Shi, do you still remember what you looked like when your sex addiction acted up? You're a thousand-year-old fox yourself—who the fuck are you pretending to be innocent for?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Regarding these things, Liang Shi couldn't deny them.

But she only addressed Cheng Ru about the current matter: "Qi Jiao doesn't care about your three parts of sincerity, so you'd better take your pitiful sincerity and get lost."

Cheng Ru sneered: "What else then? Liang Shi, have you ever loved someone? Do you know how hard it is for people like us to love someone?"

Liang Shi: ".....I don't want to know."

She just found Cheng Ru utterly exasperating.

So exasperating that she didn't want to say another word to her.

And Cheng Ru said: "I can't possibly end my current life for her."

Liang Shi was amused by her anger: "Your sincerity is too cheap."

Chapter 118-6

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The good mood from the morning was ruined by Cheng Ru.

When Liang Shi had looked at her, she'd had a whole bunch of things she wanted to say, but once she said them out loud, they carried too much of a lecturing tone.

And Cheng Ru wouldn't listen anyway.

She was too self-centered and stubborn in her views.

Gu Xingyue deserved better.

Actually, even now, Liang Shi didn't understand what Gu Xingyue liked about Cheng Ru. When together with Cheng Ru, she wasn't just at a disadvantage physically, but psychologically as well.

Before, Liang Shi had thought it was because Gu Xingyue was too obedient, so she particularly favored rogues.

But looking at it now, Gu Xingyue also had a rebellious side.

She wouldn't give Cheng Ru a second glance just because Cheng Ru was a libertine.

Cheng Ru was indeed quite pretty, but not pretty enough to be stunningly unforgettable at first sight.

This question really couldn't be figured out.

That evening when she discussed it with Xu Qingzhu, Xu Qingzhu said meaningfully: "If love could be explained clearly, it wouldn't be called love."

Liang Shi: "....."

That was true too.

The next morning, Liang Shi had to get up at five to go to the crew, so that night she slept in the guest bedroom.

After being dominated for several nights, the usage rights of this room finally returned to Liang Shi.

But after washing up, Liang Shi instinctively pushed open the master bedroom door. Xu Qingzhu was leaning against the headboard reading, still that poetry collection with the blue cover.

The sound of Liang Shi pushing the door interrupted Xu Qingzhu's reading. She looked up at Liang Shi, her eyes bewildered—actually wanting to say: What's the matter?

But Liang Shi quickly realized she had pushed the wrong door.

So in her view, that look meant: Why are you here again?

Liang Shi hurriedly apologized: "Sorry, I went to the wrong room."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

"I've gotten used to it these past few days," Liang Shi explained. "You keep reading. I'm going back to my room to sleep. You should also go to bed early, remember to set your alarm, and remember to eat breakfast."

Xu Qingzhu stared straight at her. After a few seconds, Liang Shi couldn't help asking: "What's wrong? Is there something on my face?"

Xu Qingzhu's brain didn't process before saying: "A bit good-looking."

Liang Shi: "....."

The originally quite serious atmosphere instantly relaxed.

Liang Shi instructed her that it would be colder tomorrow, so she needed to wear more.

And to remember to close the door properly when she got home, and to check who it was before opening the door. If it was a stranger, don't open it.

Also to bring her suppressants¹, and not to stay up too late.

Just like an adult about to leave home instructing a child staying behind.

After Liang Shi finished speaking, she looked toward Xu Qingzhu and found that Xu Qingzhu's pupils weren't even moving—clearly her mind had wandered.

Liang Shi helplessly raised her voice a bit: "Xu Qingzhu."

Xu Qingzhu immediately responded: "Here."

Just like a student answering roll call.

Liang Shi asked her: "What did I just say?"

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

Xu Qingzhu directly changed the subject: "I was thinking, it takes 21 days for a person to form a habit, so... is it possible..."

"No," Liang Shi, afraid she would say something scary again, immediately said: "There's no such possibility."

"I haven't even said it yet," Xu Qingzhu glared at her.

Liang Shi's body leaned against the door, not exactly without decorum, just appearing somewhat languid.

A tall person standing there was pleasing to the eye no matter how you looked.

Liang Shi said: "Then you read. I'm going back to my room."

With a hint of escape in her manner.

But Xu Qingzhu directly exposed her evasion: "It's possible that your subconscious brought you to my room."

Liang Shi: "....."

"It's not," Liang Shi denied.

On this kind of issue, she would absolutely not admit it.

Xu Qingzhu shrugged: "Alright then."

With a somewhat helpless tone, combined with her posture, as if saying—whatever you say is what it is.

Liang Shi hurriedly said: "Good night!"

Xu Qingzhu called out to her: "Wait."

Liang Shi raised an eyebrow: "Mm?"

"What time are you leaving tomorrow?" Xu Qingzhu asked her.

Liang Shi answered: "Five in the morning, maybe four-something, depending on the situation. My alarm is set for four-forty."

Xu Qingzhu asked again: "How many days will you be gone?"

Liang Shi shook her head: "Hard to say. Once you join a crew, you basically stay until your scenes wrap. At least half a month."

Like Zhao Ying and the others might need to film for a month or so.

Liang Shi's scenes were also concentrated together. If they were scattered, she would have to stay with the crew for over a month.

And Liang Shi's filming locations were all in the suburbs of Haizhou City and within Haizhou City itself, not far away.

Unlike Zhao Ying and the others, who still had to go to another province to film for a period of time.

Footnote:

¹ Suppressants (抑制剂): In ABO dynamics, medication that Omegas take to suppress their heat cycles or reduce the intensity of their pheromones. This is a standard element in ABO fiction to help Omegas function normally in society.

Chapter 118-7

Xu Qingzhu nodded to herself, her movements slow, her eyes rolling around, not knowing what she was pondering.

Liang Shi asked: "What's wrong?"

"Come here," Xu Qingzhu raised her head to look at her, suddenly speaking with a commanding tone.

Liang Shi: "....."

"What is it?" Liang Shi asked as she walked in. "Do you want me to turn off the light for you?"

She happened to walk to the bedside. Her face, just washed, was like white jade porcelain, without a single flaw visible. Standing at Xu Qingzhu's side, she casually pressed off the bedside lamp, then couldn't resist patting Xu Qingzhu's head.

Liang Shi really loved the feel of stroking Xu Qingzhu's hair.

Soft and smooth.

When she petted Xu Qingzhu's hair, Xu Qingzhu's expression would be especially obedient.

Liang Shi coaxed her: "Read for a bit then go to sleep."

Her gentle voice in the quiet room was like honey that wouldn't dissolve.

But Xu Qingzhu made space for her: "Keep me company a bit longer."

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi followed her words and sat on the edge of the bed, asking: "Can't sleep?"

"Can you fall asleep?" Xu Qingzhu asked back. "It's only nine o'clock."

Liang Shi: ".....Force myself to sleep."

Xu Qingzhu glanced at her, closed the book in her hand and set it aside, asking with less than full certainty: "You're leaving for half a month?"

Liang Shi nodded: "This is still on the short side."

She hadn't caught the longing and reluctance in Xu Qingzhu's words.

Xu Qingzhu frowned: "How long is a long one?"

"Some go abroad to film, or go into dense forests—those are generally three months minimum, some over a year. But on average it's three to four months."

"That long," Xu Qingzhu asked. "No weekends? No holidays?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi laughed. Seeing her expression was too serious, she couldn't resist pinching her face.

The gesture was light, carrying a doting quality.

Liang Shi said: "You think it's like working at your company? Filming for one day wastes a day's worth of money. The entire crew has hundreds or thousands of people—the moment the cameras start rolling, money is being spent. It's different from you."

Xu Qingzhu clicked her tongue: "The office building we bought isn't money? Water and electricity are also money, and the company also has several hundred employees."

Liang Shi: "....."

"Yes, yes, yes," Liang Shi went along with her words. "President Xu makes a valid point, but film crews are generally small budget. Better directors can get bigger sponsors, but at most it's just tens of millions—can't compare to you wealthy and powerful corporate types."

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

Xu Qingzhu's foot extended from under the covers and kicked at her. Liang Shi immediately pressed it down.

Xu Qingzhu said: "You're insulting me, aren't you?"

Liang Shi: "I wouldn't dare."

"It's that you wouldn't dare," Xu Qingzhu said with certainty. "Not that you wouldn't."

Liang Shi: "Then it's that I wouldn't. How could I insult you?"

Xu Qingzhu scoffed lightly: "Your whole face is written with—evil capitalists."

Liang Shi tucked her somewhat cold feet into the covers and covered them properly: "Other people are evil capitalists, but President Xu is a beautiful capitalist. It's different."

"If your crew had investment, could you take time off?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi, suddenly sensing danger, asked: "What for? You want to throw money at me?"

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

She hadn't thought of that originally, but Liang Shi's reaction was so extreme that Xu Qingzhu suddenly felt playful. She nodded: "Yeah, would that work?"

Liang Shi: ".....Just... if you don't want me to go out, I... can compromise. You don't need to spend money."

Xu Qingzhu was stunned for a few seconds after hearing this: "So I should build you a golden house¹? Hide you away?"

"Hide me for how many years?" Liang Shi went along with her words.

Xu Qingzhu asked her back: "How many years do you want to stay?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Seeing the topic getting more and more off track, Liang Shi couldn't help smiling as she ruffled Xu Qingzhu's hair, messing it up with a few strands sticking up.

Liang Shi rubbed her head and said: "President Xu, put away your investor tricks. I just want to film my drama in peace."

"But you're leaving for half a month," Xu Qingzhu said.

That cool voice softened, carrying an indescribable, unclear meaning that made Liang Shi's heart itch.

She looked at Xu Qingzhu, their gazes meeting in the air.

Liang Shi's throat rolled. After a moment, she sighed and opened her arms to her: "Come here for a hug."

Footnote:

¹ Golden house (金屋): Reference to the Chinese idiom "金屋藏娇" (jīn wū cáng jiāo), literally "hiding a beauty in a golden house." It originates from a historical story about Emperor Wu of Han who as a child promised to build a golden house for his cousin if he could marry her. The phrase now refers to keeping a mistress or lover hidden away in luxury.

Chapter 118-8

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When Liang Shi's alarm didn't go off in the morning, she was already awake. To avoid waking Xu Qingzhu, she tiptoed out of bed and opened the door.

But Xu Qingzhu still woke up. Her just-woken voice carried a hint of petulance as she asked if Liang Shi was leaving.

Liang Shi responded with a "mm": "I'm going to wash up, then I'll drive off. You keep sleeping."

Only Xu Qingzhu's bedside lamp was left on in the room, without much light.

As Liang Shi lay there, her heartbeat drummed like thunder.

Xu Qingzhu limply extended a hand from under the covers and grabbed onto Liang Shi's clothes.

Liang Shi's hand fell on the back of her hand. She had also just woken up, her mind still foggy, and asked Xu Qingzhu: "What's wrong?"

Her voice was gentle and indulgent.

Xu Qingzhu squinted her eyes. She was clearly so sleepy she couldn't keep her eyes open, but she just had to look at her, rubbing her head against her arm.

Liang Shi was instantly amused by her, her heart itching as she kissed her forehead.

"Be good," Liang Shi said. "I'll call you tonight."

"Video call," Xu Qingzhu made her request.

"Okay."

After Liang Shi agreed, Xu Qingzhu still wouldn't let go.

As Liang Shi bent down, her long hair fell down, landing right on the back of Xu Qingzhu's hand. She continued coaxing: "Be good, I'm leaving now."

No different from how she usually coaxed Ling Dang.

Even more attentive than coaxing Ling Dang.

Xu Qingzhu rubbed against her sleeve again, her voice cool but tone soft and sweet: "Jiejie~"

Liang Shi's heart completely melted.

She hadn't known Xu Qingzhu could be this clingy.

"I'm only going for half a month," Liang Shi patiently explained. "If I have few scenes in between, I'll come back."

She still had tasks to complete.

She didn't know what key point needed to be triggered to get those last two luck points.

Liang Shi had thought about it a lot but couldn't figure it out, so she just gave up.

When it triggered, the system would tell her.

But she guessed she at least needed to be by Xu Qingzhu's side to trigger it. Logically, she shouldn't be going off to film at a time like this—she should be staying by Xu Qingzhu's side.

But when opportunity came, there was absolutely no reason to push it away.

At worst, she just wouldn't complete that task and wouldn't get her body back.

This body was also hers anyway.

.....

From initial resistance to acceptance to now accepting it well—this was largely thanks to Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu had said that the body was merely a vessel to hold the soul.

The most important thing about a person was their soul, not the vessel.

These words successfully made Liang Shi lose her obsession with completing the task.

Hearing this, Xu Qingzhu still didn't let her go. Liang Shi bent down to look at that face in the dim yellow lamplight. She licked her lips and placed a kiss on Xu Qingzhu's lips.

Lips lightly touching lips, separating at first contact.

Liang Shi ruffled Xu Qingzhu's hair, her heart soft as mush, tucking her hands and feet back under the covers. She leaned close to her ear and said in a low voice: "Zhuzi, I'm leaving now. Sleep well."

Chapter 118-9

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Before leaving, Liang Shi went downstairs and found that the breakfast shop downstairs had already opened.

She simply bought breakfast and left it upstairs before driving off.

By the time she arrived at the crew, daylight had already broken, and the timing was just right.

The filming location was a rented villa, even more extravagant than the Liang family's old mansion.

There were also some exterior scenes—the crew had built everything on location.

This luxurious place didn't just have their crew filming; there was another crew filming a Republican-era¹ drama in the back garden.

After Liang Shi arrived, she immediately went to the main makeup room to get her hair and makeup done. Four or five extras were getting ready at the same time.

Today, Liang Shi was filming scenes with Yan Xi.

In the script, her scenes with Yan Xi were all in the latter part. What they were filming now was still from their later scenes, but due to location constraints, they were shooting by location.

The crew had communicated about this in advance, so Liang Shi had already familiarized herself with the script.

But when she was getting her makeup done, Yan Xi hadn't arrived yet.

By the time Liang Shi's makeup was half done, Yan Xi arrived late, yawning, waving her hand like a lucky cat²: "Morning."

"Morning," Liang Shi replied.

As soon as Yan Xi sat down, her eyelids drooped and she couldn't keep them open.

Seeing this, Liang Shi asked her: "What did you do last night?"

"Writing papers," Yan Xi said. "And homework."

Liang Shi: "....."

She didn't understand the world of academic overachievers.

Though...

"Did you memorize your lines?" Liang Shi asked.

Yan Xi sat there like a puppet, letting the makeup artist manipulate her: "Memorized them. Know them super well."

Hearing this, Liang Shi felt somewhat relieved.

But Yan Xi said: "You don't trust me? Let me tell you, even though I've never acted before, everyone praises me for having natural talent."

Liang Shi: ".....That's good then."

After a while, Liang Shi added: "I don't trust myself. After all, I don't have much experience, so it would be bad if I dragged you down."

Yan Xi: "....."

Yan Xi was satisfied and lightly hummed: "Good that you know."

After a pause, she added: "Student Xu is an idol to many people at our school. Her learning ability is super strong. Don't embarrass her."

Liang Shi: ".....?"

Liang Shi thought of what Xu Qingzhu had learned recently from Sally and Lin Luoxi, and couldn't help sighing. Perhaps an academic overachiever's learning ability was reflected in all aspects.

In terms of drawing inferences from examples, integrating knowledge, and deriving new insights from old knowledge, Xu Qingzhu had indeed achieved perfection.

Liang Shi responded to her perfunctorily.

After their makeup and styling were finished, the two came out holding their scripts to rehearse.

Yan Xi was still somewhat tired, and even thick foundation couldn't hide her dark circles.

It wasn't until they were in the sunlight that Liang Shi discovered her dark circles were so heavy. Seeing her poor condition, she couldn't help worrying: "Can you still film like this?"

Yan Xi raised her hand and yawned again: "Yes, I'm not that delicate."

Liang Shi: "....."

Perhaps because Yan Xi's nanny wasn't here, Yan Xi's speech wasn't soft and sweet anymore.

She wasn't complaining to anyone either.

"You're underestimating the abilities of contemporary college students," Yan Xi said. "Last year I pulled an all-nighter gaming and still went to take an ex... *yawn* ...am."

Liang Shi: "....."

It seemed contemporary college students' abilities were just so-so.

But Liang Shi didn't say anything.

The initial scenes were simple. Before filming started, Yan Xi patted her forehead, then drank a bottle of ice water to wake herself up.

Once filming began, Liang Shi hadn't quite gotten into character, and Yan Xi was even worse.

The director had anticipated this situation and didn't say anything.

Two people who had just joined the crew filming together—wasting two or three takes was expected.

So they quickly rallied to film the second take. Liang Shi had already found her rhythm, but Yan Xi still wasn't quite there. That spirited face of hers showed no emotion when reciting her lines.

The director was naturally unsatisfied.

.....

After NG-ing seventeen times in a row, the director couldn't help losing his temper: "Yan Xi, can you do this? If not, let's get a replacement."

A stern voice came from behind: "Then let's replace her."

Everyone in the crew turned around in unison to look at the newcomer. The speaker was wearing a black coat over a long dress, with long curly hair—grape purple that only showed in the sunlight. She stood there with upright posture, a coat draped over her arm.

Standing beside her was a glamorous beauty, wearing a light blue long coat that reached her knees over a burgundy sweater and dark jeans—a very ordinary outfit, but paired with that face, everything became extraordinary.

Her pupils were light brown, appearing indifferent to everything under the sunlight.

Especially with that face, which carried a world-weary quality.

Distant and cold.

Liang Shi looked at the newcomers in a daze for a few seconds. Standing across from her, Yan Xi, who had been somewhat dejected, immediately brightened up: "Jiejie! Sister Hui!"

The director's expression wasn't good, feeling he'd provoked yet another big Buddha he couldn't afford to offend.

Yan Lin stood there waiting for Yan Xi to run over, handing her the coat: "Aren't you afraid of freezing?"

Yan Xi waved it away, not taking it, only asking: "Weren't you supposed to be on a date with Sister Hui today? Why did you come looking for me?"

Standing not far away, Liang Shi's heart skipped—A date?

Footnotes:

- ¹ Republican-era (民国): Refers to the Republic of China period (1912-1949), a popular setting for Chinese historical dramas featuring early 20th century fashion and culture.
- ² Lucky cat (招财猫): Also known as Maneki-neko, a common Japanese/Chinese figurine of a cat with one paw raised in a beckoning gesture, believed to bring good luck and fortune.